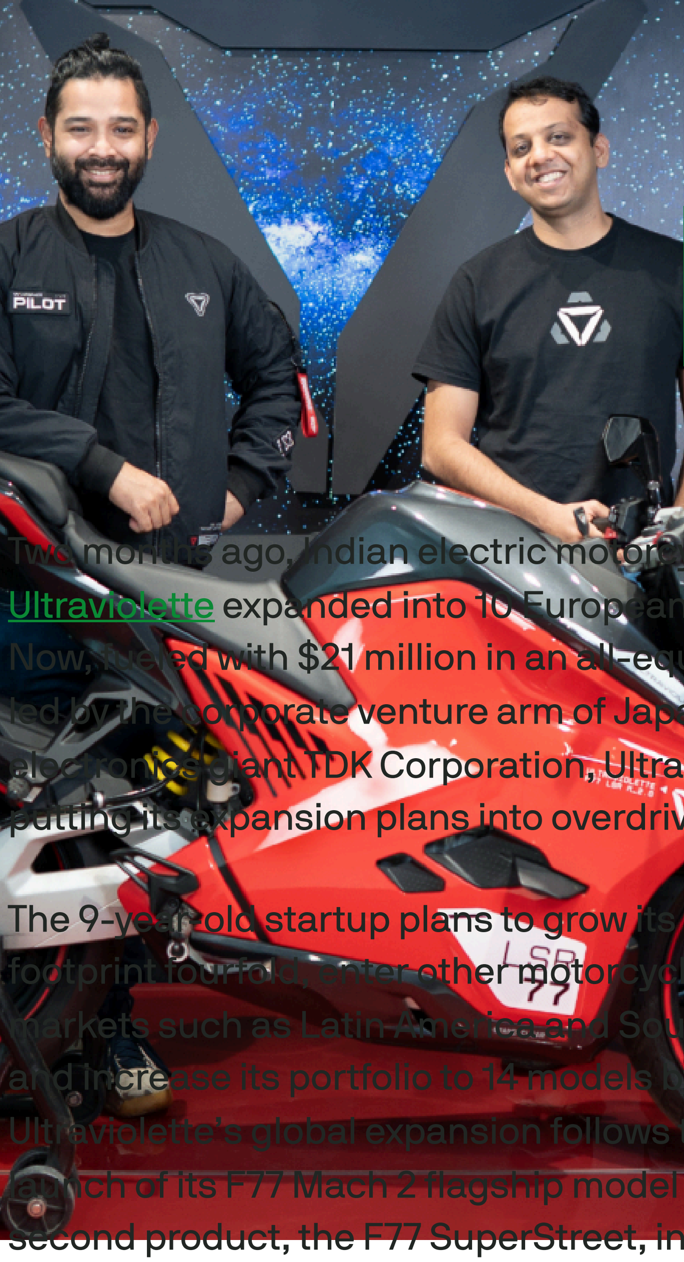
Advertisement

TRANSPORTATION

TDK backs Ultraviolette with $21M to take India-made electric motorcycles global



Jagmeet Singh — 9:30 PM PDT · August 11, 2025

Two months ago, Indian electric motorcycle startup Ultraviolette expanded into 10 European countries. Now, fueled with $21 million in an all-equity round led by the corporate venture arm of Japanese electronics giant TDK Corporation, Ultraviolette is putting its expansion plans into overdrive.

The 9-year-old startup plans to grow its European footprint fourfold, enter other motorcycle-driven markets such as Latin America and Southeast Asia, and increase its portfolio to 14 models by early 2027. Ultraviolette's global expansion follows the 2024 launch of its F77 Mach 2 flagship model and its second product, the F77 SuperStreet, in February.

IMAGE CREDITS: ULTRAVIOLETTE

Behind Ultraviolette are two childhood friends — CEO Narayan Subramaniam and CTO Niraj Rajmohan — who combined their expertise in mechanical engineering, automotive design, computer science, and electronics to electrify the mid-segment two-wheeler market.

The duo, which drew inspiration from Tesla, started Ultraviolette at a time when India's electric two-wheeler market was dominated by low-speed models, mainly catering to commercial and utility needs. The early boom was driven by Chinese imports offering low-cost options, followed by a wave of homegrown startups and, more recently, legacy manufacturers entering the space.

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

Book Your Table ›

Most Popular

- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach
- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue
- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request

Instead of becoming just another player in that race, the Ultraviolette co-founders set out to build electric motorcycles that could match the performance of 150cc to 800cc internal combustion engine sports bikes.

"We asked ourselves, if we have to make electric exciting in two-wheelers, what would it take? And that's the objective with which we started," said Rajmohan (pictured above, right) in an exclusive interview.

The Bengaluru-based startup took about four years from its inception in 2016 to unveil the first model in 2019. The startup went through multiple design iterations before finalizing the seventh version — hence the name F77. The commercial version debuted with a fixed battery pack to deliver over 186 miles of range and a top speed of 96 miles/hour with 30kW peak power and up to 100 newton-meters of torque.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to $600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

- NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars
- Why I finally left Spotify

Ultraviolette has also unveiled the lightweight Shock Wave motorcycle as well as the Tesseract scooter, which features front and rear radar and cameras to enable an assisted-driving experience and blindspot detection. The scooter costs ₹145,000 ($1,650), while its motorcycles (ex-showroom) have a base price of ₹175,000 ($2,000) and go up to $10,000.

ULTRAVIOLETTE F77 MACH 2 IMAGE CREDITS:ULTRAVIOLETTE

Ultraviolette's vehicles come equipped with eSIM connectivity and feature predictive maintenance powered by a proprietary diagnostics system. Rajmohan said the system can detect even minor issues, such as when the chain needs lubrication. The startup offers an app that provides all these insights to consumers on the go.

The company has also established a manufacturing and assembly facility in Bengaluru's Electronics City, with a capacity of 30,000 units. Today, the company handles everything in-house, from developing embedded software and battery management systems to motor controllers and even battery manufacturing. About 500 people work at Ultraviolette, including 200 in corporate functions and R&D.

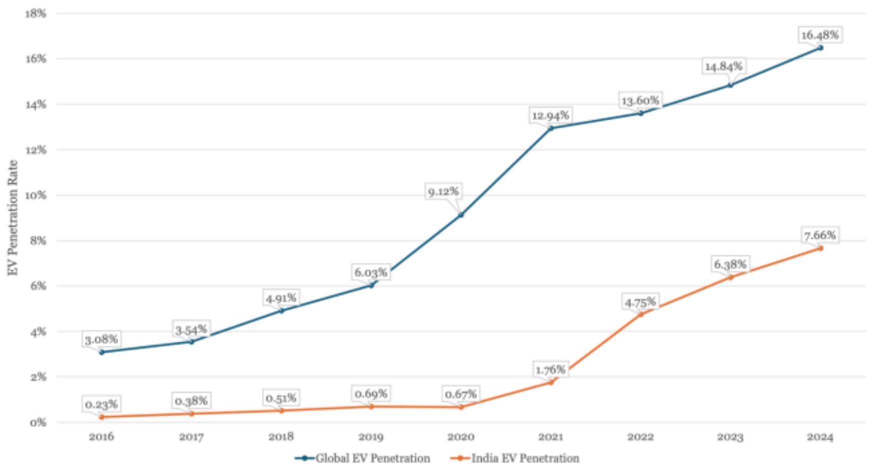
Ultraviolette's business model was shaped in part by Tesla owners. The co-founders spent time talking to Tesla owners in the U.S., who were among the first ones to buy the Model S in 2015, to learn what made that car different from other EVs of its time.

"These Tesla cars were very special, as owning them was seen as progressive. It was more of a lifestyle statement," Rajmohan told TechCrunch.

The co-founders brought that sentiment to Ultraviolette's design and branding, aiming to make it a global company from day one. As Rajmohan explained, the word "violet" is pronounced similarly in over 30 European languages, while "ultra" signals something cutting-edge. Reinforcing that ambition, the startup pursued European certification for all its vehicles even before entering the market.

This is unlike other Indian electric two-wheeler manufacturers, which have tried to cater to local demand. India accounts for nearly 40% of global motorcycle sales — although most of those are powered by internal combustion engines.

Expanding beyond India makes strategic sense for Ultraviolette, given the domestic EV market remains relatively underpenetrated — with adoption at just 7.66%, compared to the global average of 16.48%, according to a recent report by government-backed think tank NITI Aayog. While India aims to reach 30% EV penetration by 2030, progress so far suggests that it may be an ambitious target.



EV PENETRATION RATE — GLOBAL AND INDIA

IMAGE CREDITS:NITI AAYOG

India is also a price-sensitive market, where two-wheelers are typically not discretionary purchases, but essential and affordable modes of daily transportation. As a result, selling high-end variants at scale in the country could be a challenge for Ultraviolette — at least initially.

"We were very clear that what we're doing is, we're working toward segments which are more universal in nature," Rajmohan said.

What's next?

ULTRAVIOLETTE'S MANUFACTURING PLANT IN BENGALURU

IMAGE CREDITS:ULTRAVIOLETTE

Ultraviolette plans to expand the capacity of its Bengaluru production facility to up to 60,000 units and add a larger location to scale to about 300,000 units by early next year. Ultraviolette operates 20 stores across 20 Indian cities and plans to grow to around 100 by March next year. About 50 of those stores — one per city — are expected to open by the festive season later this year.

Rajmohan told TechCrunch the startup is working on expanding its European presence, where it has 40 dealers.

"Next year is where the scale-up happens in Europe," he said.

The startup also plans to start its pilot in Latin America and Southeast Asia next year and go to markets including the U.S. and Japan later.

Ultraviolette has sold more than 3,000 motorcycles in India and has projected to sell up to 10,000 later this year. It has also targeted over $50 million in revenue by the end of this financial year.

The new funding saw participation from Ultraviolette's existing investors Zoho Corporation and Lingotto (previously Exor Capital). To date, it has raised around $75 million in funding and counts Qualcomm Ventures, Exor, and TVS Motor among its other key investors.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: electric motorcycle Exclusive India Startups TDK Corporation TDK Ventures Transportation Ultraviolette

Jagmeet Singh

Reporter

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

View Bio

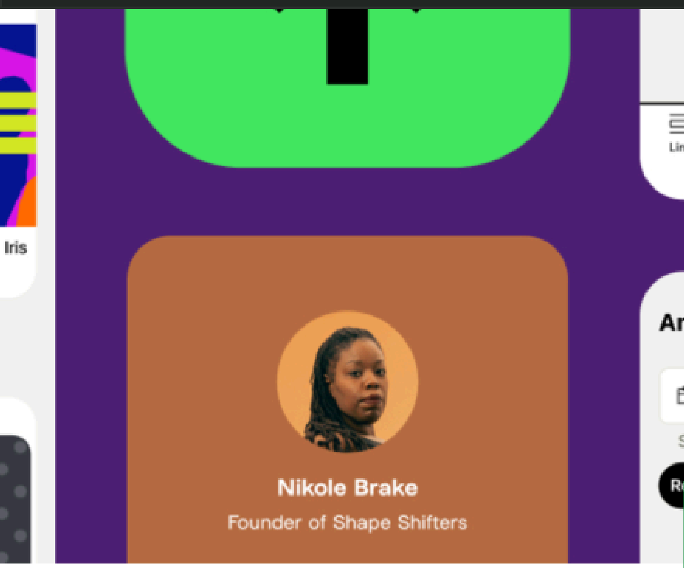


IMAGE CREDITS: LINKTREE

India — and the company isn't sure why

Jagmeet Singh — 7:46 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Linktree, the popular link-in-bio service used by millions of creators and businesses, has been inaccessible in India for several days — and its sudden disappearance from the Indian web remains a mystery, even to the Australian startup itself.

Over the past week, Linktree has been inaccessible in India, with a few users raising the issue on X. Initially, TechCrunch noticed that the site briefly displayed a message suggesting it had been blocked by the Indian government. Later, this was replaced by a generic SSL protocol error. The Linktree app has also been inaccessible in the country.

Founded in 2016, Linktree became a unicorn in 2022 and surpassed 50 million users in 2024. India has been the platform's fifth-largest market by traffic, accounting for 3.5% of its global visits — or about 7.3 million in July, per Similarweb data shared with TechCrunch.

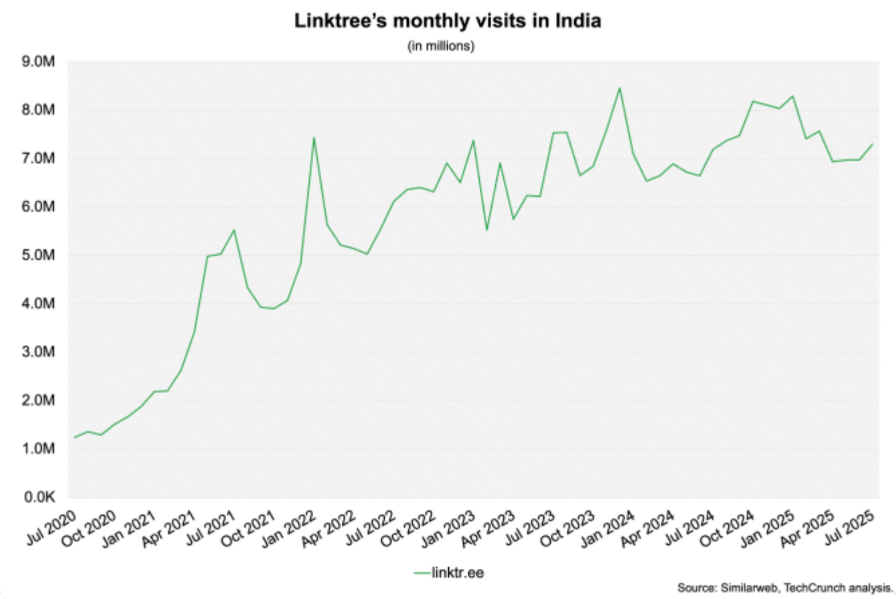


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Newsletters See More ↗

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News
Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly
Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review
Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility
TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our Terms and Privacy Notice.

Linktree co-founder and CEO Alex Zaccaria told TechCrunch that the startup was looking into the situation. However, the executive did not confirm whether the startup received a communication from Indian authorities on its blockage.

The startup later posted on X that it was aware of the service outage in India and was "investigating" the issue.

As reported by the Indian daily The Hindu, the outage is not limited to a specific internet service provider and appears to affect all major networks.

The U.S. remains Linktree's top market, with 48.5 million visits, followed by Indonesia (32.3 million), Brazil (30.8 million), and the U.K. (9.4 million), Similarweb data shows.

India's IT and telecom ministries did not respond to emails sent over the weekend.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: Apps Government & Policy India Linktree Social Startups

Jagmeet Singh

Reporter

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

View Bio

KEEP READING

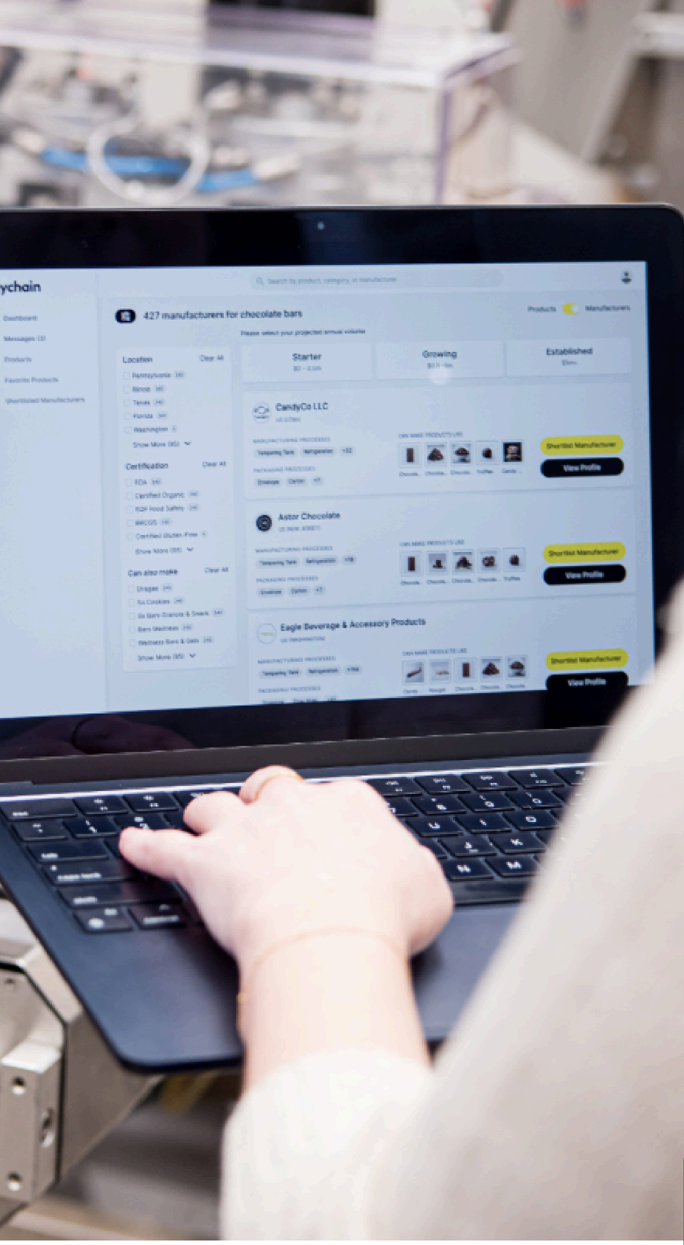


IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

ENTERPRISE

CPG startup Keychain snags $30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Keychain, a U.S. startup that helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners, has raised $30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team

Advertisement

Latest in Enterprise

already represents half of Keychain's 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in in Gurugram — which is the country's second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

"It's the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India]," said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a "natural advantage" in building Keychain's core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.

See More

CLIMATE

Aalo Atomics raises $100M to build a microreactor and data center together

Tim De Chant - 6 minutes ago

ENTERPRISE

CPG startup Keychain snags $30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

ENTERPRISE

SoftBank makes $2B investment in Intel

Kirsten Korosec - 15 hours ago

Advertisement

KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA (LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain's teams across India and the U.S., ultimately choosing India as the company's engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it challenging to build a "sustainable, enduring" engineering team in the U.S.

"We've thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that's got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that's commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes," Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to $600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Several U.S. startups, especially those developing SaaS solutions, base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs, often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say India is harder to sell into — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK's Deliveroo and Southeast Asia's Gojek and Grab — all of which tap into India's tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

"India's position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country," said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.

KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is aiming to enter Europe later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from $10,000 to over $100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around $20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain’s Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised $68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over $50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of $260 million in its last round of $15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

Topics: Enterprise India Keychain KeychainOS North America Startups United States

Advertisement

Jagmeet Singh

Reporter

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

View Bio

Loading the next article

TechCrunch

Staff

Contact Us

Advertise

Crunchboard Jobs

Site Map

Terms of Service

Privacy Policy

RSS Terms of Use

Neuralink

Google Chrome

StubHub

Claude

GPT-5

Tech Layoffs

ChatGPT

© 2025 TechCrunch Media LLC.